



Everything you need to know

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By October, Paris usually belongs to the artists, the dreamers, and the lovers. This year, it belongs to VALORANT. For three weeks, the Arènes de Grand Paris Sud has traded classical music for the crackle of Phantom bursts, and poetry for perfectly timed clutches. The VALORANT Champions Tour's capstone event – the fifth in the esports' young but roaring history – has descended on France with a promise: crown a world champion and celebrate half a decade of unforgettable competition.

Yet, instead of a predictable coronation, Paris has turned into a stage for classic esports chaos, heartbreak, and reinvention.



THE FALL OF THE GIANTS

The group stage, designed to test nerves and adaptability, became a graveyard for titans. Defending champions EDward Gaming, who wrote

China's name in bold on VALORANT's global map last year, have been sent packing before the playoffs even began. Their loss to NRG was more than just defeat, it was a sobering reminder that staying on top is harder than getting there.

And then came the shockwave heard across the Atlantic: Sentinels, North America's most iconic team, eliminated early after losses to GIANtx and XLG Esports. Their storied brand, once synonymous with clutch plays and championship swagger, left fans with little more than memes, frustration, and the familiar sting of “what could have been.”

For Chinese fans, the heartbreak deepened. Alongside EDG, both Bilibili Gaming and Dragon Ranger Gaming fell, leaving XLG as their last hope.

HEROES RISING

If this stage is merciless, it is also generous, ready to crown new heroes.

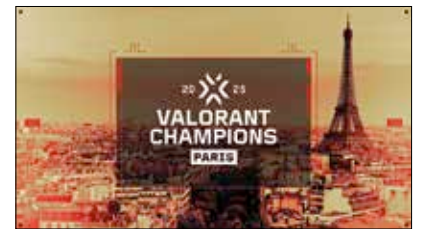
NRG have carried the torch for the Americas with style. Their takedowns of DRX and EDG weren't just wins, they were statements. North America, often dismissed as inconsistent, suddenly looks dangerous again.

From Europe, Team Heretics lit up the tournament with a performance

no one predicted. Their 2–0 dismantling of G2 Esports didn't just earn them a playoff spot, it forced analysts, fans, and perhaps even G2 themselves to ask uncomfortable questions about the balance of power in EMEA. G2 did bounce back eliminating DRG in dominant fashion and now must face T1 for their last chance at making the playoffs.

Paper Rex (PRX), ever the entertainers, brought their signature chaos to Paris. With flashy plays and fearless confidence, they brushed aside both XLG and GIANtx, confirming that the Pacific juggernaut's Masters Toronto win was no fluke.

And then there's Fnatic. The only organization to appear at every single Champions, their story is now tradition. By defeating MIBR and RRQ, they reminded everyone why consistency, not just raw talent, defines greatness.



THE STORY ISN'T OVER

As of September 19, the scoreboard reads like a thriller:

Qualified for Playoffs: NRG (Americas), Fnatic (EMEA). Paper Rex (Pacific) and Team Heretics (EMEA)

Eliminated: Sentinels (Americas), EDward Gaming (China, 2024 champs), Bilibili Gaming (China) and Dragon Ranger Gaming (China)

If the first week of VCT Paris 2025 has taught us anything, it's this: the crown will not be handed easily. Champions are falling, underdogs are rising, and the heart of VALORANT beats loudest in chaos.

The Arènes de Grand Paris Sud is just getting warmed up. The lights will grow brighter, the stakes heavier, and the matches more brutal. Somewhere among the remaining teams lies the next world champion. *